



DID THEY USE THE RULE OF THIRDS IN BLADE RUNNER 2049 - PART ONE

How's everyone doing? Welcome back to another exciting article! Huge thanks for all of the continued support everyone, you keep this blog going! Thanks to Andre for inspiring this post (see [#446](#)).

Today we are going to dig deep into [Blade Runner 2049](#), the exciting **sequel** being released in October, 2017. They released a pretty awesome **trailer** and the visuals they included are pretty stunning and use plenty of **composition** and **design** techniques, but the question we all want to know is if they used the **rule of thirds** or **dynamic symmetry**. That's a big question, and I'm going to simply answer and prove it in part one of this three part article. Oh, and I'll be introducing a **new root rectangle** that has never been covered anywhere before! Let's get into it and see how they infused this trailer with jaw dropping visuals and how they did it.

Official Trailer

Before we go any further, I think it would be a great idea to check out the trailer if you haven't already. Keep your eyes peeled for **triangular** shapes (see [Day 87](#)), **diagonals**, and amazing use of **light**. We also want to make note of subject placement.

BLADE RUNNER 2049 Trailer - For Educational Purposes Only

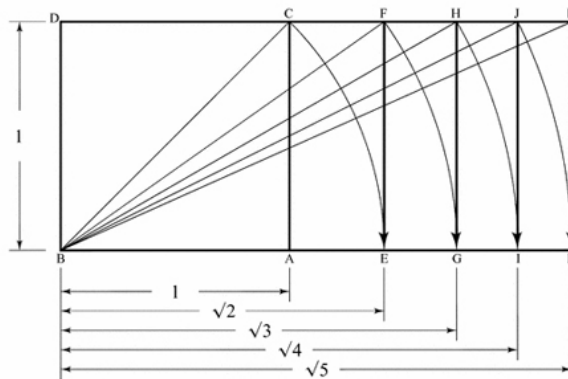
One of the coolest visuals from the trailer can be seen below. Tons of great clips, but this one stands out to me, so I figured I would use it to set the stage for the images to follow in part two.



A Bit of Dynamic Symmetry Review

We don't need a review on the rule of thirds (it's that simplified) and I hate to even suggest that a beautiful movie like this used it to guide their composition, but every now and then I have to play devil's advocate. So, here we have just a quick couple of notes on dynamic symmetry just in case the cob webs have reemerged inside your brain.

All root rectangles are created with the square as we can see below.



The cinematic frame we are analyzing was thought to be a **21:9 ratio**, which can be broken down to a decimal point of 2.333 (21 divided by 9), but after analyzing the screen shot I learned that it is a **2.40 ratio**. In an attempt to confirm this, I looked up the technical specifications on [IMDb](#), but it is listed as **2.35**, which is wrong.

How do I know this is wrong? Well, I did the math and put in some elbow grease to measure the frame in Photoshop. Below you will see some comparisons to the different ratios used in cinematography and in the dynamic symmetry system of design.

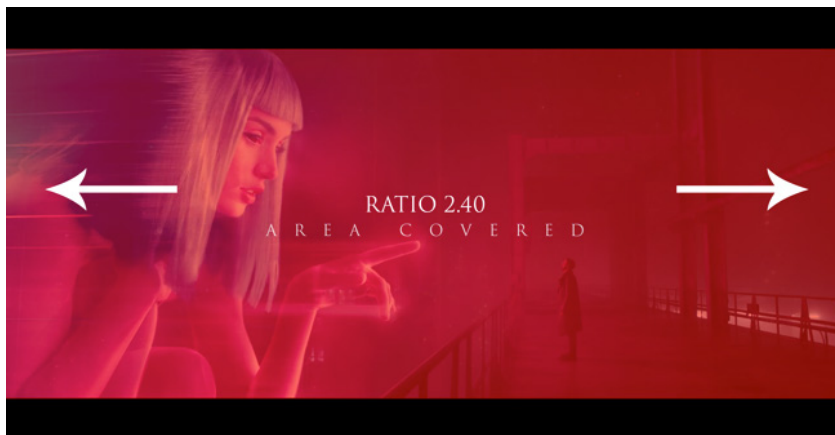
The red part is the area covered by each ratio. We can see with the 21:9 ratio that there is still a bit left on the sides.



With the 2.35 ratio, there's still a bit left on the sides that isn't covered. We are talking decimal points, which isn't really going to matter when using a properly constructed grid for each ratio, but I like to point out that they did *indeed* use the ratio of 2.40 for the movie, which we will see next.



Here we see the 2.40 ratio which covers the entire area.



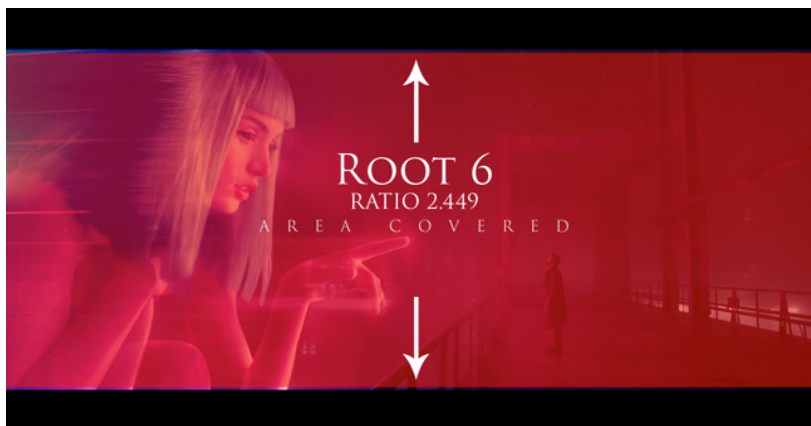
In the previous article (see [#446](#)) I analyze the framing with the root 5 because it belongs to a system of design rather than being an arbitrary grid or the rule of thirds. The only thing is, the sides don't quite cover the area. This is completely fine and the benefits of dynamic symmetry still apply even though there is a **slight difference** in the area coverage. Perfect would be amazing, but close enough works fine too.



So, going back to the ratio used of 2.40, we can take this and try to match it closely to the root rectangle that is closest to sharing a similar ratio. For as long as I've been studying and teaching dynamic symmetry, the closest root rectangle that I've had the experience of using is the root 5 with a 2.236 ratio.

Being a perfectionist I decided to dig deeper. I thought to myself, "wait a sec, what about the root 6 ratio?" I didn't learn about this rectangle in [The Barnstone Studios](#) because it was deemed too long for any reasonable application. That is, unless you're a cinematographer! This ratio is as close to perfect as we could hope for, and I'm excited to have discovered the use of this brand new (to this site) root rectangle!

Look how close it is to the 2.40 ratio...only a bit at the top and bottom aren't covered. Wow!



Analyzing Blade Runner 2049 with ROT or Dynamic Symmetry

As I looked at most of the visuals from the trailer, I was happy to see that they weren't simply **plotting** their subjects on the **rule of thirds** and calling it good. Typically with any of the cinematography or photography instructors on YouTube, they continually harp about the **benefits** of using ROT, but I'm going to stress that it's not a good idea, and there are no benefits...as expected.

I lined up this visual to the rule of thirds grid and was immediately **disappointed**. I thought to myself, maybe they weren't using dynamic symmetry. Maybe they just got lucky with diagonals in some of the scenes. But we have to remember why people still think **master painters** used the rule of thirds...because some of the lines are in very similar locations as we'll soon discover.



As we can see in the example below, the root 6 rectangle covers the cinematic frame almost perfectly. It's perfect enough for me and lines up better than the root 5, for sure. Even though the small size adjustment from the root 5 to the root 6 wouldn't make much difference when applied to cinematography, it's still nice to have it be close to perfect. Plus, we are still using the dynamic symmetry system, which is ideal.



Now, typically I break down the dynamic symmetry grids on the **theme of two** because all of the root rectangles have a theme of two (aka **numeric dynamic theme**, see [#438](#)). But as we've

learned, we can create many different themes within the mother root rectangle, so I'm going to use the "root 6 rectangle on the theme of 3x" ($\sqrt{6}:3x$). All this means is that we have nine root 6 rectangles inside the mother as seen below (themes explained further in [#438](#)).



Doing this creates locations for **thirds placement**, but it's not the rule of thirds because we are utilizing diagonals and many other techniques like a **counterpart** (see [Day 57](#)), **gazing direction** (see [Day 99](#)), **pointing devices**, **figure-ground relationship** (see [Day 21](#)), **greatest area of contrast** (see [Day 27](#)), and **aerial perspective** (see [Day 42](#)) all in one shot.

Note: As with everything, I'm **skeptical** about modern cinematographers (not master painters) and they could've easily used the rule of thirds and got lucky with some diagonals and placement, but I have to give them the benefit of the doubt and assume they are using dynamic symmetry. Mostly because of some of the other visuals, which we'll cover in part two. Even if we find out they didn't use dynamic symmetry, and did *indeed* get lucky, we'll still see how we can apply this to our cinematography and take luck out of the equation.

So, let's analyze this screenshot to the root 6:3x. I'm looking at the diagonals here. Check out her hair and pointing arm...they seem to be paralleling the reciprocal. Pretty cool right? Now let's look at the placement of each character in the detail examples following.



We have to assume that there is a digital designer involved for this scene, and they could totally design this scene in the way we are analyzing it.

On the left side, we can see how her hair is on a vertical, the face is paralleling the reciprocal, and the eyes are paralleling the major sinister diagonal. Her pointing finger is almost locked into the baroque diagonal, and who knows...maybe in the final film we'll see that it starts it's initial motion being locked into the baroque diagonal.



On the right side we can see how the subject is locked into the vertical, but check out the structure design in the background. From the left side to the right, and the diagonal on the upper right. This all locks in exact! This is what leads me to believe they used this grid system and not the rule of thirds.

Are you starting to see how sophisticated the dynamic symmetry is compared to the rule of thirds? It's the difference between a Michelin Star restaurant vs Airplane food.



Conclusion

In part two, I'll go into detail of what areas of the grid to avoid and why.

The rule of thirds doesn't have diagonals and it **forces** you to plot your subject on a crosshair...or otherwise "break the rules". We don't have to do that with dynamic symmetry, and the root 6 rectangle is perfect for us! If you're a cinematographer, try to learn this design system for your own cinematic shots and incorporate more organization, repeating diagonals, and the other powerful techniques mentioned above.

...to be continued